

Song Lab

Hear chords, build beats, and map your song. Scan the code or type:

cmfnyc.github.io/song-lab/



Melody & Hook Toolkit

The Hook Recipe

1. **Find a rhythm you can tap.** Tap it on the table over your loop.
2. **Put it on 2–3 notes.** That's all you need.
3. **Repeat it.** Two, three, or four times.
4. **Change the ending** the last time. Go higher, or land on the home note.

Many famous hooks use only two or three different notes. The **rhythm** is what makes them catchy.

Six rules for a melody people remember

1. **Repeat.** Repetition is catchiness.
 2. **Keep phrases short.** 2–5 words, then a breath.
 3. **Mostly steps, one leap.** Move to neighbor notes most of the time. Save one big jump for the most important word.
 4. **Chord tones on strong beats.** On beats 1 and 3, use a note that's in the chord. It will sound "right." (Chord notes are on the Chord Cheatsheet.)
 5. **Chorus higher than verse.** Higher = more energy.
 6. **Leave space.** Rests let the listener breathe and remember.
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Catching ideas

- Loop your groove and **hum** over it. Use "la," "na," "oh." Words come later.
- Record **everything** on Voice Memos. Ideas vanish in minutes.
- Do **three takes** without stopping to judge. Then listen and pick.

- No singing? Find the melody on your instrument, one note at a time.
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Writing it down (おんぷノート)

1. Make a **chord chart** on paper: bar numbers, the chord for each bar, and its three notes. (The app can't show chord names.)
2. In the app, set the **key signature and 4/4**.
3. **Handwrite** notes one bar at a time. Zoom in; a stylus helps. **Play back after every bar**.
4. Check beat 1 of each bar: is the note on your chord chart for that bar?
5. Sour note? Move it **one step up or down**.
6. Try different **playback sounds**. Which one sounds like your song?
7. **Export a PDF** before you finish. The app keeps only one score.

More tips: [Using おんぷノート](#)

The One-Listen Test

Play your chorus for someone once. Can they hum the hook back?

- **Yes** → you have a hook.
 - **No** → simplify the rhythm, repeat more, or use fewer notes.
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Level 2 tricks

- **Question and answer:** first phrase ends "up in the air" (unfinished); second phrase ends on the home note (finished).
 - **Pickup:** start the melody just before beat 1.
 - **Anticipation:** land an important note half a beat early (on the "&" before the beat). Sounds modern and groovy.
 - **Displacement:** repeat the hook but start it one beat later.
 - **Air pocket:** a moment of silence right before the chorus.
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My hook

Hook words (or syllables): _____

Rhythm (tap it, then write dashes for each note): _____

Notes it uses: _____

Passed the One-Listen Test? yes / not yet